

The Hound of Troy

The Vengeance of Hecuba

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This is the opening of The Hound of Troy — the first two chapters, complete and unabridged. It ends where the war begins.

CHAPTER ONE

Queen of Asia

There was a city, once, that the gods themselves had built, and if you had stood upon the summit of Mount Ida on a clear morning in the age before everything went wrong, you would have seen it glittering at the edge of the world like a jewel set into the throat of the Hellespont, its walls so white they seemed to have been carved from the bones of the earth itself, its towers so tall they pricked the bellies of passing clouds and made them weep, which the citizens of Troy took to be a sign of divine favour (and which was, in a certain sense, exactly that, though not in the way they imagined). The city of Troy, called Ilion by some and the Crown of Asia by others and simply home by the quarter of a million souls who dwelt within its concentric rings of limestone and marble, was the richest, the most beautiful, and the most arrogant settlement that the ancient world had ever produced, and at the very top of it, in a palace that sprawled across the citadel like a cat stretching in a patch of sunlight, there lived a woman who was, by almost any measure one cared to apply, the most powerful queen on earth.

Her name was Hecuba.

She had not always been a queen, of course. No one is born a queen, though a great many people are born

believing they ought to have been, which is not at all the same thing and tends to produce rather different results. Hecuba had been born a princess of Phrygia, the mountainous kingdom that lay to the east of Troy like a shaggy green cloak thrown over the shoulders of the continent, and her father, King Dymas, had been the sort of minor sovereign who spent most of his reign worrying about grain stores and border disputes and whether the neighbouring tribes would raid his cattle again before the autumn rains. He had loved his daughter in the distracted, slightly bewildered way that fathers of exceptionally capable daughters often do, and he had given her away to Priam of Troy with a mixture of pride and relief, the way a man might hand over a sword that had always been slightly too large for him to wield comfortably.

Priam had not been a young man even then. He was already greying at the temples when Hecuba first saw him stride through the gates of her father's modest palace, and his face bore the particular expression of weary patience that belongs to men who have already buried one wife and are not entirely sure they have the energy for another. He had been married before, to a woman called Arisbe, whom he had put aside with a generosity that was either magnanimous or insulting depending on whom you asked (Arisbe, for her part, had married a man called Hyrtacus and moved to the countryside, where she raised horses and never spoke of Priam again, which was probably the wisest

thing anyone in this story ever did). But Priam needed sons. Troy needed sons. The great city with its god-built walls and its harbour choked with merchant ships and its treasury that glowed with gold from a dozen conquered territories needed heirs the way a fire needs fuel, and Hecuba, who was young and strong and clever and who looked at the world with the calm, assessing gaze of a woman who understood exactly what was being asked of her and had already decided to exceed expectations, was the answer to a prayer that Priam had not quite known how to articulate.

She gave him sons.

She gave him so many sons that the palace nurseries, which had been built to accommodate a reasonable number of royal children (say, four or five, with perhaps a daughter or two for diplomatic marriages), had to be expanded three times in as many years, knocking through walls and commandeering whole wings of the citadel until the sound of children crying and laughing and breaking things echoed through the corridors at all hours and the palace servants developed the particular glazed expression of people who have long since given up trying to keep count. Fifty sons, in the end. Fifty boys who grew into fifty young men who filled the halls of Troy with their noise and their ambitions and their quarrels, and if that number seems extraordinary (which it is), it should be noted that not all of them were Hecuba's. Priam, like most kings of his era, kept a number

of concubines, and several of the fifty were born to women whose names history has not bothered to record, which tells you something about what history considers worth remembering and something else about the particular cruelties of being a woman in a palace. But the ones who mattered, the ones whose names would ring through the centuries like bells struck in an empty cathedral, were Hecuba's.

Hector was the first, and he was, from the moment he drew his first breath and screamed at the ceiling of the birthing chamber with an indignation that seemed almost personal, everything that a firstborn prince of Troy should be. He was large. He was strong. He grew into the kind of boy who could throw a javelin farther than men twice his age and who wept openly when his favourite hound was injured in a hunt, which was exactly the combination of strength and tenderness that makes a good ruler and a terrible enemy. Hecuba loved him with a ferocity that frightened her sometimes, a love so total and so consuming that it felt less like an emotion and more like a geological feature, something carved into the bedrock of her being that could not be eroded by time or circumstance or even, as it would turn out, by death.

After Hector came Paris, and Paris was trouble.

She knew it before he was born. She knew it in the way that mothers sometimes know things, not through reason or evidence but through something older and deeper,

something that lives in the blood and the bone and that whispers warnings in a language that the waking mind cannot quite translate. She dreamed, in the last weeks before his birth, of fire. Not a hearth fire or a torch or the controlled blaze of a sacrifice, but a wildfire, a consuming thing that roared through the halls of Troy and licked at the walls and turned the white stone black and the golden roofs to rivers of molten metal that ran down the hillside like tears. She woke gasping, her hands pressed to the great dome of her belly, and she could feel the child inside her turning, restless, as though he too could see the flames.

But that dream, and what was done about it, belongs to another chapter. For now, let us stay with Hecuba at the height of her power, in the years before the dream and the prophecy and the war and the fire and the grief and the blood and the dog, in the years when she was simply and magnificently the Queen of Troy, and the world bent itself around her like water around a stone.

The palace of Troy was not one building but many, a sprawling complex of colonnaded halls and open courtyards and private apartments that had been added to and expanded by every generation of Priam's dynasty until it resembled less a single structure than a small city within a city, which was, in a sense, exactly what it was. The great hall, where Priam held court and received embassies from kingdoms as distant as Egypt and Mesopotamia and the wild coasts of what would one day be called Italy, was a

cavern of polished stone with columns as thick as oak trees and a ceiling so high that the smoke from the braziers gathered in the upper reaches like storm clouds, drifting and coiling in patterns that the more superstitious courtiers claimed to read like omens. The floor was a single expanse of fitted marble, each piece cut and polished until the joints between them were invisible, and when the morning light came through the eastern windows it turned the whole surface into a sheet of liquid gold that you could see your face in, which was useful for foreign ambassadors who wished to check their appearance before approaching the throne but rather less useful for anyone trying to walk across it in leather sandals (the palace had a dedicated team of servants whose sole responsibility was catching people who slipped).

Hecuba moved through this palace the way a spider moves through its web, with an absolute and instinctive awareness of every strand and every vibration. She knew which servants were stealing from the kitchens (most of them, but only in amounts she considered acceptable). She knew which of her sons were feuding with each other this week and whether the feud was the sort that would resolve itself over a shared amphora of wine or the sort that required her to intervene with a sharp word and, on occasion, a sharper slap. She knew which ambassadors could be trusted and which were spies, and she knew the difference between the two, which was less than most

people supposed, since all ambassadors are spies and all spies are, in their own way, ambassadors for someone.

She ran the household with a precision that would have impressed a military commander, which was appropriate, since running a palace with fifty princes, several hundred servants, a fluctuating population of concubines, and an ageing king who was increasingly prone to fits of sentimentality was, in fact, a more complex logistical operation than most military campaigns. The kitchens alone required a small army of cooks, bakers, butchers, and wine stewards, and the laundry (fifty princes produce an astonishing volume of dirty clothing, particularly when half of them spend their afternoons wrestling in the dust of the training grounds) was a daily crisis that Hecuba managed with the same calm authority she brought to matters of state.

She was not, it should be said, a warm woman. Not in the way that the word is usually meant, with its implications of softness and approachability and the kind of maternal cosiness that invites confidences and forgives failures. Hecuba was warm the way a forge is warm: intensely, purposefully, and with the understanding that the warmth existed to shape things, to heat raw metal until it could be hammered into something useful. Her sons respected her. Most of them feared her, at least a little. Hector alone seemed to understand her completely, to see through the iron exterior to the molten core beneath, and it

was Hector alone who could make her laugh, a sound so rare and so unexpected that servants who heard it for the first time often stopped what they were doing and stared, the way people stare at a rainbow or a comet or any other natural phenomenon that they know is real but cannot quite believe they are seeing.

Priam, for his part, loved her and was slightly terrified of her, which is the ideal state of affairs in any long marriage and one that both parties had arrived at independently and without discussion. He consulted her on matters of trade and diplomacy and war not because custom required it (it did not; queens of Troy were expected to concern themselves with the household and the temples and leave the business of governance to the king and his council) but because Hecuba's judgment was, quite simply, better than anyone else's. She had a gift for seeing through pretence and flattery to the hard truth beneath, the way a skilled physician can see through skin and muscle to the bone, and Priam had learned, through long and sometimes painful experience, that ignoring her advice was an excellent way to find oneself in exactly the sort of trouble she had predicted.

"You are too soft," she told him once, during a dispute with a Hittite trading delegation that had been dragging on for weeks. They were in their private apartments, Priam sprawled on a couch with a cup of wine balanced on his chest in a way that made Hecuba's fingers itch to straighten it, and she was standing by the window, watching the

harbour below, where the Hittite ships sat in the water like fat, self-satisfied geese. “They do not respect softness. They interpret it as weakness, and they are not entirely wrong to do so.”

“I am negotiating,” Priam said, with the dignity of a man who knows he is losing an argument but has not yet decided to admit it.

“You are surrendering by degrees,” Hecuba replied. “Which is still surrendering. It simply takes longer and costs more wine.”

The Hittite delegation left the following day with roughly half of what they had asked for, which was exactly what Hecuba had calculated they would accept, and Priam added another small notch to the long mental tally he kept of times his wife had been right about things he wished she had been wrong about.

The wealth of Troy was legendary, and like most legends, it was simultaneously exaggerated and inadequate. The city sat astride the Hellespont like a toll-keeper on a bridge, and every ship that passed between the wine-dark Aegean and the cold, fish-rich waters of the Propontis paid tribute in gold or goods or both. The warehouses along the harbour were stacked with amphoras of olive oil from Lesbos, bolts of purple-dyed wool from Sidon, ingots of tin from the distant, fog-shrouded islands that the Phoenician traders called the Cassiterides and refused to say more about (the Phoenicians, as a people, had elevated secrecy

about trade routes to something approaching a religious obligation), copper from Cyprus, amber from the frozen rivers of the north, and enough grain to feed the city for a year, which was stored in underground silos carved into the bedrock beneath the citadel and guarded with a zeal that bordered on the fanatical.

The gold, though. The gold was something else entirely.

Troy's treasury was housed in a chamber beneath the palace that could only be reached through a series of corridors so convoluted and so heavily guarded that even Priam, who owned everything in it, found the journey mildly annoying. The room itself was not large (treasure rooms, in Hecuba's experience, were never as large as people imagined; it was remarkable how much wealth could be compressed into a relatively modest space when that wealth took the form of gold), but what it lacked in size it compensated for in the sheer, almost obscene density of its contents. Gold cups and gold plates and gold jewellery and gold figurines and raw gold ingots stacked like bricks against the walls, all of it gleaming in the torchlight with a warm, buttery radiance that made the air itself seem to glow, and in the centre of the room, on a pedestal of black basalt, sat the Palladium.

The Palladium was a wooden statue of Athena, no taller than a man's forearm, and it was, by a considerable margin, the ugliest object in the room. It was roughly carved, primitively painted, and had the general appearance of

something that a talented but unsupervised child might produce if given a piece of olive wood and a sharp knife and told to make a goddess. Its eyes were too large. Its mouth was a flat line that could have been a smile or a grimace or simply the result of the carver's hand slipping at a critical moment. One of its arms was raised in a gesture that might have been a blessing or a threat, and the other held a small wooden spear that was slightly crooked and had been repaired at least twice with resin and leather strips.

It was the most valuable object in the city, worth more than all the gold combined, because as long as the Palladium remained within the walls of Troy, the city could not fall. This was not a matter of superstition or tradition but of divine guarantee, handed down through generations of kings and confirmed by oracles and seers and the occasional direct statement from the gods themselves (who were, on the whole, rather more communicative in those days than they would later become, though their communications tended toward the cryptic and the unhelpful, which is rather the defining characteristic of divine speech across all cultures and all ages). Hecuba visited the Palladium once a month, not to pray (she was not, in her heart, a woman who prayed, though she observed the forms with meticulous correctness) but to check on it, the way a general checks on a fortification, with a cool, professional eye that assessed its condition and its security and found both satisfactory.

Troy could not fall. The walls were god-built. The Palladium was safe. Her sons were strong and numerous. Her husband was wise, if occasionally soft. The treasury was full. The harbour was busy. The fields beyond the walls were green with wheat and barley, and the herds on Mount Ida were fat, and the rivers ran clean, and the gods, so far as anyone could tell, were pleased.

It was perfect, which should have been the first warning.

Hecuba had fifty sons, and she loved them all, but she did not love them equally, because mothers who claim to love all their children the same are either lying or have not been paying attention. She loved them according to their natures and their needs and, if she was honest with herself (which she usually was, since dishonesty with oneself is the most expensive kind of dishonesty and Hecuba was, above all things, economical), according to how much trouble they caused her.

Hector, as has been said, was the firstborn and the favourite, though Hecuba would have denied this with a vehemence that would have convinced no one. He was twenty-three now, broad-shouldered and steady-eyed, married to Andromache of Thebes (the Cilician Thebes, not the famous one with the seven gates, which was a distinction that Andromache found herself explaining with wearying frequency), and already a father himself. His son, Astyanax, was barely a year old, a plump and cheerful infant who had inherited his father's impressive lungs and

his mother's dark eyes and who seemed, at this early stage, to be developing a personality that was half Hector's steadiness and half something wilder and more unpredictable that Hecuba privately attributed to the influence of Andromache's side of the family (the Cilicians being, in Hecuba's considered opinion, a slightly volatile people, though she would never have said so aloud, since Andromache was the one daughter-in-law she genuinely liked).

Hector was the man who would be king after Priam, and everyone knew it, and no one resented it, which was remarkable enough in a family of fifty brothers that it deserves special notice. He trained with the army every morning, heard petitions in the afternoon, dined with his parents in the evening, and read to his son at night, and he did all of these things with the same patient, unhurried thoroughness that characterised everything he did. He was not brilliant in the way that some of his brothers were; he did not have Helenus's gift for prophecy or Deiphobus's savage skill with a sword or Paris's infuriating, effortless charm. What Hector had instead was something rarer and more useful: he was reliable. He was the kind of man upon whom things could be built, the kind of foundation that holds the weight of whatever is placed upon it without complaint and without cracking, and Hecuba, who understood the value of foundations better than anyone in Troy, treasured him accordingly.

Paris was another matter entirely.

Paris was beautiful. This was not a subjective assessment or a mother's bias but a simple, observable fact, as undeniable as the blueness of the sky or the wetness of the sea. He was, by common and indeed nearly universal agreement, the most beautiful man alive, which was a distinction that carried with it a number of practical inconveniences that no one ever seemed to mention until it was too late. Beautiful people, in Hecuba's experience, tended to develop a relationship with the world that was fundamentally different from everyone else's, because the world was constantly offering them things (admiration, forgiveness, opportunities, the benefit of every conceivable doubt) that other people had to earn, and this created in them a kind of expectant passivity, a sense that the universe existed primarily to arrange itself for their comfort, which was harmless enough in a shepherd or a merchant's son but potentially catastrophic in a prince.

Paris had been sent away as a baby, for reasons that Hecuba did not like to think about and that will be discussed at the proper time, and he had grown up on the slopes of Mount Ida among the herdsmen and their flocks, not knowing who he was, which was meant to be a solution to a problem but had, in the way of such things, merely created a different problem. When he returned to Troy (and he did return, because the sons of kings always return, the way rivers always find the sea, no matter how many

obstacles are placed in their path), he was a young man who combined extraordinary physical beauty with an almost complete lack of practical wisdom, which was roughly the equivalent of giving a child a very sharp, very expensive sword and being surprised when he cut himself.

But we are getting ahead of ourselves.

Deiphobus was fierce and proud and slightly too fond of killing things. Helenus was quiet and strange and spoke in riddles that turned out, much later and always too late, to be prophecies. Troilus was young and golden-haired and loved by everyone, including, fatally, by certain gods who showed their love in ways that mortals could not survive. Polites was loyal and overlooked, which is the natural condition of middle sons in very large families. Pammon and Antiphos and Hippothous and Chromius were brave warriors who fought well and died well and whose names have survived twenty-three centuries only because they happened to be brothers of more famous men, which is a kind of immortality, if not the kind that anyone would choose.

And Polydorus. The youngest. The last.

Polydorus was twelve years old and still had the soft, unfinished look of a boy who has not yet decided what kind of man he will become. He was Hecuba's baby, her final child, born when she had thought her childbearing years were over and received with a tenderness that surprised even her, because she had thought, after forty-nine sons

and however many daughters history had neglected to count, that she had used up whatever store of maternal softness she possessed. But Polydorus, with his shy smile and his thin wrists and his habit of following Hector around the palace like a small, devoted shadow, had found reserves she did not know she had. She was gentler with him than she had been with any of the others, not because he was better but because he was last, and because she was older now, and because age does not make us wiser (that is a lie that old people tell to justify having survived) but it does, sometimes, make us kinder, which is not the same thing but may, in the end, be more important.

He was twelve years old, and he loved his mother, and she loved him, and this, in the particular and merciless universe of Greek mythology, meant that something terrible was going to happen to at least one of them.

The daughters of Hecuba are a footnote in most tellings of this story, which is itself a commentary on who gets to be remembered and why. There were many of them (the exact number varies depending on which ancient source one trusts, and since none of them can be trusted completely, let us say many and leave it at that), but two among them burned with a light that could not be dimmed even by the vast, obliterating shadow of the brothers' fame.

Cassandra was the elder, and she was cursed.

She had been beautiful, once, in the sharp, slightly unsettling way that a knife is beautiful, all edges and gleam

and the promise of pain. The god Apollo had loved her (which was, in the vocabulary of the gods, a term that encompassed everything from genuine devotion to something considerably more predatory and self-serving, and usually landed closer to the latter) and had given her the gift of prophecy, which is to say that he had opened her eyes to the future the way one might open a window onto a landscape that was entirely on fire. She could see everything that was going to happen, and everything that was going to happen was terrible, and no one would ever believe her, because that was Apollo's punishment for refusing him, which tells you everything you need to know about the gods and their gifts and the price they extract for what they claim to give freely.

Cassandra wandered the palace like a woman haunted by her own mind, her dark hair tangled, her eyes too wide, muttering warnings that the servants had learned to ignore and that Hecuba had learned to endure with a tight-lipped patience that cost her more than she ever admitted. There were days when Cassandra was almost normal, when she would sit in the women's quarters and spin wool and speak in sentences that had beginnings and middles and ends, and on those days Hecuba would look at her daughter and see, with a pain that felt like a hand closing around her heart, the woman Cassandra might have been if the gods had left her alone. And there were other days when Cassandra screamed.

She screamed about fire. She screamed about blood. She screamed about ships, a thousand ships with black hulls and bronze rams, sailing across the Aegean like a swarm of insects. She screamed about Hector lying dead in the dust, about Priam murdered at his own altar, about babies thrown from walls and women dragged by their hair through burning streets. She screamed about all of it, every detail, every horror, and she screamed it with such conviction and such specificity that anyone who listened carefully would have had ample warning to prevent everything that followed, which was, of course, exactly the point of the curse: the truth was always available, always audible, and always, always ignored.

Hecuba listened, and did not believe, and this was not because she was stupid or incurious or dismissive of her daughter's suffering. It was because believing Cassandra would have meant accepting that everything she had built, everything she loved, everything she had spent her life creating and protecting and polishing to a high, hard shine, was already lost. It would have meant looking at Troy, at its walls and its towers and its treasury and its harbour and its princes and its king, and seeing not a city but a pyre waiting to be lit. And Hecuba, who had the kind of mind that dealt in practicalities and solutions and the careful management of knowable problems, simply could not accommodate a truth that large and that final. So she did what human

beings have always done when confronted with a truth they cannot bear: she looked away.

Polyxena, the younger daughter, was everything Cassandra was not: gentle, quiet, conventionally beautiful in a way that did not make people uneasy, and blessed (or cursed, depending on your perspective) with a complete absence of prophetic ability, which meant that she moved through the world with the pleasant obliviousness of someone who cannot see the cliff edge they are walking toward. She was kind. She tended the household shrines. She was good with the younger children. She would, in another story, have married well and lived quietly and been remembered only as a footnote in someone else's genealogy, which would have been a perfectly acceptable fate and one that Hecuba would have arranged for her with the same brisk efficiency she brought to all her domestic projects. But Polyxena, like everyone else in this family, was not going to get the life she deserved.

On the evening that this story properly begins (though in truth it had been beginning for a long time, accumulating momentum the way a boulder accumulates speed on a hillside, slowly at first and then with a terrible, unstoppable inevitability), Hecuba stood on the western terrace of the palace and watched the sun go down over the Aegean.

It was late summer, and the air was thick with the smell of ripening figs and warm stone and the faint, salt-tinged breeze that came off the sea in the evenings and made the

palace torches gutter and dance. Below her, the city descended the hillside in a series of broad terraces, each one ringed with walls and packed with houses and workshops and temples, the whole intricate structure lit from within by thousands of individual fires that made Troy look, from above, like a constellation that had decided to settle on the earth for a while and see how the other half lived. The harbour was dark except for the riding lights of a few merchant ships, their hulls creaking softly against the quay, and beyond the harbour the sea stretched away into a darkness so absolute that it was impossible to tell where the water ended and the sky began.

Hecuba was fifty-two years old. Her hair, which had once been as black as a raven's wing (an overused comparison, but in this case an accurate one), was streaked with grey at the temples, and the skin around her eyes had developed the fine network of lines that comes from years of squinting at problems and refusing to look away from things that other people preferred not to see. She was still handsome, in a hard, composed sort of way, the way a well-built fortress is handsome: not pretty, not decorative, but impressive in its solidity and its obvious capacity to withstand assault. She wore a gown of deep purple wool, fastened at the shoulders with gold brooches that had been her mother's, and her hair was pinned up with ivory combs in the elaborate Trojan style that required the assistance of two handmaidens and approximately forty-five minutes of

patient work, which Hecuba endured every morning with the stoic resignation of a woman who understood that appearance was a form of armour and that armour, however uncomfortable, was not optional.

She was thinking about grain.

This was not, she knew, the sort of thought that the poets would record. When the bards sang of Hecuba in the centuries to come (and they would sing of her, she was certain of that, though the songs would not be the ones she would have chosen), they would describe her grief and her rage and her transformation, the great dramatic moments that lent themselves to verse and metaphor. They would not mention the grain stores, or the diplomatic correspondence, or the complicated arrangements she had made with the Phrygian traders for next season's supply of wool. They would not describe the hours she spent each day reviewing accounts and settling disputes and managing the intricate web of alliances and obligations that kept Troy's economy functioning, because these things were not dramatic and they were not beautiful and they did not make for good poetry, but they were the things that made everything else possible, the invisible infrastructure upon which the visible glory of Troy was built, and Hecuba knew this even if no one else did.

Priam joined her on the terrace as the last light faded. He moved slowly these days, his joints stiff with age, and he leaned on a staff of polished cedar that he pretended was

ceremonial and that was, in fact, entirely necessary. He stood beside her and looked out at the city, his city, the city his father Laomedon had expanded and his grandfather Ilus had founded and the gods Poseidon and Apollo had built the walls of (under duress, as part of a punishment from Zeus, which meant that the walls of Troy were the product of divine labour performed reluctantly, and there are those who have argued that this explained certain structural irregularities in the south-west corner, though this seems like rather a stretch).

“Beautiful,” Priam said, which was what he always said when he stood on this terrace and looked at Troy, and which was true, and which Hecuba acknowledged with a nod that managed to convey both agreement and the faintest suggestion that beauty, while pleasant, was not the point.

“The Phrygian envoy arrives tomorrow,” she said. “You should wear the gold diadem, not the silver. He will be assessing our wealth.”

“They are all always assessing our wealth,” Priam said, which was also true, and which was also not the point, and Hecuba permitted herself a small sigh that was, in its own way, a form of affection.

They stood together in silence for a while, the king and the queen, watching the lights of their city flicker and glow beneath them. The night was warm. The sea was calm. Somewhere in the palace behind them, one of the younger

princes was practising the lyre, badly, and the sound drifted out through the windows and mixed with the chirping of the crickets and the distant laughter of the harbour guards changing shifts. It was peaceful, and perfect, and it would not last, but they did not know that yet, and so they stood and watched and breathed the warm night air, and Hecuba thought about grain and gold and the Phrygian envoy's known appetites and the best way to leverage them, and Priam thought about his city and his sons and his queen and how fortunate he was, and neither of them thought about fire.

Not yet.

But in the women's quarters, behind a door that was bolted from the outside (for her own safety, they said, though whose safety was really being protected was a question that no one wanted to examine too closely), Cassandra sat in the dark with her arms wrapped around her knees and her eyes open and seeing, seeing, seeing everything that was coming, and she whispered a single word into the silence.

"Burn."

And the night went on, and Troy glittered, and the gods looked down from Olympus with the patient, pitiless interest of children watching an anthill, and Hecuba, Queen of Troy, Queen of Asia, the most powerful woman in the ancient world, slept soundly in her bed beside her husband

and dreamed of nothing at all, which was, given what was coming, perhaps the last true mercy she would ever receive.

CHAPTER TWO

The Prophecies

The trouble, as trouble so often does, began with a dream.

It was not the first dream. Hecuba had been dreaming strange, vivid, unsettling dreams for most of the pregnancy, which was her second (Hector was three years old, a solemn, watchful toddler who had recently discovered the word “no” and was deploying it with the relentless consistency of a siege engine). The midwives assured her that strange dreams were perfectly normal during pregnancy, that they were caused by an excess of black bile or a shift in the humours or the influence of the moon or any of the other explanations that people offered when they did not, in fact, know what was happening and felt that saying so would be unhelpful. Hecuba had nodded and said nothing and continued to dream, and the dreams grew worse.

She dreamed of snakes. She dreamed of water rising up through the floor of the palace, black and cold, filling the corridors until the torches sputtered and went out. She dreamed of her own hands covered in blood, though in the dream she did not know whose blood it was, and the not knowing was somehow worse than any answer could have been. She dreamed of a sound, a low, terrible roaring that

she could feel in her bones, that shook the walls and cracked the marble floors and made the gold cups on the shelves dance and ring against each other like bells.

And then, three weeks before the child was due, she dreamed of the torch.

It was the most vivid dream she had ever had, so sharp and so detailed that it felt less like a dream than like a memory of something that had not happened yet, a memory from the future, which is a contradiction in terms that nevertheless captures exactly what the experience was like. She was lying in the birthing chamber, and the pain was real (this was the part that convinced her, afterwards, that it was more than an ordinary dream, because pain in dreams is usually muted and indistinct, a suggestion rather than a sensation, and this pain was as specific and as overwhelming as anything she had ever felt), and the midwives were around her, their faces tense, their hands busy, and then the child came, and it was not a child.

It was a torch.

A burning, blazing, screaming torch that erupted from her body like a coal spat from a furnace, and the moment it touched the air it exploded outward in a wall of flame that consumed the birthing chamber and the palace and the city and the world, and Hecuba could see Troy burning, every building, every wall, every tower, the harbour and the ships and the training grounds and the temples and the marketplace, all of it wrapped in fire so hot that the stone

itself turned to liquid and ran down the hillside in rivers of molten white, and the screaming, the screaming of a quarter of a million people burning alive, was the worst sound she had ever heard, worse than any nightmare, worse than anything she had imagined suffering could sound like, and through it all the torch burned on, insatiable, incandescent, beautiful in its destruction the way a wildfire is beautiful when you see it from far enough away that you cannot smell the flesh.

She woke screaming.

The servants came running. Priam came, grey-faced and limping without his staff, his crown forgotten, his thin hair standing up in wild tufts that made him look, in the flickering lamplight, like a startled owl. He held her while she shook and he asked her what she had seen, and she told him, and she watched his face change as she spoke, watched the colour drain from it like wine draining from a cracked cup, and she knew, with a certainty that sat in her stomach like a stone, that this dream was different from all the others.

This dream was true.

Priam called the seers.

This was the natural response of any Trojan king confronted with a troubling omen, because the Trojans, like all the peoples of the ancient world, believed that the future existed in a completed form somewhere beyond the reach of ordinary perception, like a scroll that had already been

written but not yet unrolled, and that certain gifted (or cursed) individuals could catch glimpses of what was written there through dreams, through the flight of birds, through the patterns in a sacrificed animal's entrails, or through the particular way that oil spread on the surface of a bowl of water, which was called lecanomancy and was considered one of the more respectable divinatory arts, though "respectable" is perhaps a generous word for the practice of staring at an oily puddle and claiming to see the future in it.

The chief seer of Troy was a man called Aesacus, who was, rather inconveniently, one of Priam's own sons (by a previous wife, not by Hecuba, which placed him in the awkward position of being simultaneously a prince and a prophet, two roles that do not combine comfortably, since princes are expected to tell kings what they want to hear and prophets are expected to tell them the truth, and these are rarely the same thing). Aesacus had the thin, angular look of a man who has spent too much time staring into the middle distance, and his eyes had the particular quality of seeming to focus on something that was not in the room, which was disconcerting during formal dinners but was considered a mark of genuine prophetic ability. He had studied the arts of divination under his grandfather, the seer Merops of Percote, who was widely regarded as the finest interpreter of omens in all of Asia Minor, and who had once correctly predicted the outcome of a war between

two Phrygian cities by examining the entrails of a goat (the goat, it should be noted, had not volunteered for this role, but then neither had Merops, who had originally wanted to be a potter).

Aesacus listened to Hecuba's dream in silence. He sat very still, his hands folded in his lap, his strange unfocused eyes fixed on a point somewhere above and behind Hecuba's left shoulder, which she found irritating but was too shaken to comment on. When she finished speaking, he closed his eyes and was silent for so long that Priam, who was pacing behind Hecuba's chair with the restless energy of a man who wants to do something but does not know what, began to wonder if his son had fallen asleep.

He had not fallen asleep. He was listening. Not to Hecuba, whose account was finished, but to something else, something that moved beneath her words the way a current moves beneath the surface of a river, invisible but powerful, shaping everything above it without being seen. The dream had a meaning, and the meaning was clear, and it was terrible, and Aesacus, who had spent his entire life learning to read the language of the divine, wished with all his heart that he had become a potter after all.

"The child," he said at last, opening his eyes, and his voice had the flat, colourless quality of a man reporting a fact that he takes no pleasure in. "The child that the queen carries will be the destruction of Troy."

The room went very quiet.

“It is... it is not ambiguous,” Aesacus continued, with the apologetic tone of someone who wishes the news were better and knows that wishing will not make it so. “The torch is the child. The fire is war. If this child lives, Troy will burn.”

Priam stopped pacing. His face had gone from grey to white, which is the colour that shock paints on the faces of old men, and his hands, clasped behind his back, were trembling in a way that he could not quite control. He looked at Hecuba. Hecuba looked at Aesacus. Aesacus looked at the floor, because he was wise enough to know that there are moments when not being looked at is a form of mercy.

“What do you advise?” Priam asked, and his voice was very careful, very controlled, the voice of a man who is holding something fragile (his composure, his sanity, his faith in a world that made sense) and is terrified of dropping it.

Aesacus swallowed. “The child must be... exposed.”

The word hung in the air between them like smoke. Exposed. It was the polite, clinical term for what was, in practice, the act of taking a newborn infant to a wild and desolate place and leaving it there to die, which was, in the ancient world, a recognised and socially acceptable (if not exactly celebrated) method of dealing with children who were unwanted, or deformed, or born under bad omens, or simply one child too many for a family that could not afford

another mouth to feed. It was considered more humane than direct killing (which it was not, but human beings have always been remarkably creative in their ability to categorise their cruelties in ways that make them easier to live with), and it carried with it the faint, hypocritical comfort of plausible deniability: the child was not murdered, it was merely placed somewhere, and if it happened to die, well, that was the will of the gods, and who were mere mortals to interfere with the will of the gods?

Hecuba said nothing.

This, more than anything else, tells us who she was.

A different woman might have wept. A different woman might have begged, or argued, or thrown herself on her husband's mercy, or snatched up the prophecy and torn it to pieces and declared that she would not, could not, would never allow her child to be harmed. A different woman might have done any of these things, and the poets would have admired her for it, and the story would have been the same, because the child would still have been exposed (Priam was a king, and kings do not change their minds because their wives weep; they change their minds because their advisors present them with better options, and no one was presenting better options), and the weeping would have accomplished nothing except to make Hecuba look weak, which she could not afford, not now, not ever.

So she said nothing. She sat in her chair with her hands resting on the swell of her belly, on the child that was already kicking, already turning, already reaching toward the world it would destroy, and she looked at Priam, and her face was as still and as hard as the walls of the city she was trying to save, and she gave a single nod that was the smallest possible motion a human head can make and still be considered agreement.

Priam nodded back.

And that was how they decided to kill their son.

The child was born three weeks later, on a morning so bright and clear that the whole city seemed to be made of light, which was exactly the kind of weather that makes tragedies feel more tragic, because if it had been raining, at least the sky would have had the decency to match the mood. He was a boy, as the prophecy had predicted, and he was perfect, as perfectly formed and as beautiful as any child Hecuba had ever seen, with dark hair already curling at his temples and a face that seemed, even in the wrinkled, red, compressed state of the newly born, to promise something extraordinary.

Hecuba held him for exactly one hour.

This was not the hour that the poets describe, the hour of anguished maternal farewell in which the mother weeps and kisses the child and makes speeches about fate and duty and the cruel necessities of kingship. Hecuba did none of these things. She held the child against her chest and she

looked at him, studying him with the same cool, assessing gaze she brought to trade negotiations and military briefings, and she memorised him, every detail, the curl of his ear, the particular shade of pink of his lower lip, the tiny, perfectly formed fingernails, the smell of him, which was the universal smell of newborns, a warm, slightly sour, indescribably tender smell that is unlike anything else in the world and that is designed, with the ruthless efficiency of nature, to make the holder want to protect the source of the smell at any cost.

Nature, in this case, lost.

Or perhaps it would be more accurate to say that one instinct overcame another. The instinct to protect the child was real and powerful and ancient, older than thought, older than language, wired into the deepest structures of the human brain. But the instinct to protect the city, to protect the other children, to protect the accumulated work and wealth and meaning of a civilisation that had taken generations to build, was also real, and in Hecuba it was not merely an instinct but a deliberate, reasoned, conscious choice, which made it stronger than instinct in the same way that a wall is stronger than a hedge: both serve the same purpose, but one has been designed and built with intention, and the other has simply grown.

She handed the child to a servant, a man called Agelaus, who was one of Priam's herdsmen on Mount Ida and who had been chosen for this task because he was reliable and

discreet and not particularly imaginative, which were exactly the qualities one wanted in someone being asked to carry a baby into the wilderness and leave it there. Agelaus took the child and held it at arm's length, the way one holds something that one is not entirely sure is safe, and he looked at Hecuba with an expression that was half question and half plea, and Hecuba looked back at him with no expression at all, and Agelaus turned and walked out of the chamber and did not look back, because looking back would have required a courage that he did not possess and that no one had asked of him.

Hecuba watched him go. She watched the door close behind him. She listened to his footsteps fade down the corridor, and then she listened to the silence that came after, and then she stood up (slowly, because her body was still raw and bleeding and shaking from the birth) and she walked to the window and she looked out at Troy, at the city that she had just saved, at the white walls and the golden roofs and the busy harbour and the green fields beyond, and she felt...

Nothing.

Which was not true, of course. She felt everything. She felt a grief so vast and so total that it seemed to fill the world, to press in on her from every direction like water at the bottom of the sea, crushing and cold and relentless. But she had decided, in the hour she spent holding her son, that she would not feel it, that she would take the grief and the

guilt and the love and the rage and fold them up like a garment that is no longer needed and put them away in a dark place inside herself where they could not be seen and could not interfere with what needed to be done, and this she did, with a discipline that was either admirable or monstrous or both, and the grief stayed there, in the dark, folded and waiting, for twenty years.

It should be noted, for the sake of completeness and because this story does not permit the comfort of ignorance, that Agelaus did not do what he was told.

He carried the child up the slopes of Mount Ida, through the pine forests and the meadows where the sheep grazed and the wild flowers grew in drifts of yellow and white, and he found a place among the rocks, a hollow sheltered from the wind, and he put the child down, and the child began to cry, and Agelaus stood there listening to the crying and looking at the mountains and thinking about his own children, two daughters and a son, who were waiting for him in his cottage at the edge of the forest, and after a while he picked the child up again.

He told himself that he would wait five days. If the child survived five days in the wild, it would be a sign from the gods that it was meant to live, and he would take it home and raise it as his own. This was the kind of reasoning that people use when they have already decided what they are going to do and need a justification that sounds like something other than what it is (which was, in this case,

simple human kindness overriding royal authority, a thing that happens more often than kings would like to admit).

The child survived five days. In some versions of the story, it was nursed by a she-bear, which is a charming detail that may or may not be true but which serves the narrative purpose of establishing the child's connection to the wild, to the untamed forces of nature that exist outside the walls of cities and the reach of kings. Agelaus took the child home. He named it Paris (or Alexander, depending on who was doing the telling). He raised it among the herds on Mount Ida, and the boy grew up strong and beautiful and utterly ignorant of who he was, which was both a blessing and a time bomb.

And Hecuba, far below in the palace, assumed her son was dead, and she went on with her life, and the grief stayed folded in the dark, and Troy went on shining, and twenty years passed.

Twenty years is a long time. Long enough for a city to forget its fear, for a prophecy to fade from a living terror into an old story that people told over wine and that nobody took entirely seriously anymore. Long enough for Hector to grow from a solemn toddler into the finest warrior in Asia, for Hecuba to grow from a young queen into a formidable matriarch whose word was law in everything except name, for Priam to grow from a vigorous king into an old man who talked too much about the past and not enough about the future, though he was still shrewd enough when the

occasion demanded it, which was, increasingly, less often than it used to be.

Cassandra had been born during those twenty years, and cursed. Polyxena had been born, and adored. Deiphobus and Helenus and Troilus and Polydorus and all the rest had come into the world in a steady procession of princes that seemed, at times, as though it would never end, each one another brick in the wall of Troy's dynastic security, another guarantee that the house of Priam would endure.

And then, one spring morning, a young man walked through the gates of Troy.

He was tall and extraordinarily handsome, with dark curling hair and eyes the colour of honey and a smile that seemed to promise, without saying anything specific, that the world was essentially a wonderful place and that wonderful things were about to happen. He was dressed in the rough wool and leather of a herdsman, but he moved with a grace that did not belong to the mountains, a fluid, confident ease that suggested either royal blood or divine favour or both (which, as it turned out, was exactly the case). He had come to compete in the funeral games that Priam had announced for a son who had died in infancy, twenty years ago, a son whose death was commemorated every year with athletic competitions and sacrifices and the particular kind of formalised grief that royal families practise as a public duty and that bears only a passing resemblance to actual sorrow.

The funeral games were for Paris. The boy competing in them was Paris. And nobody knew.

He won everything. He won the foot race and the wrestling and the boxing and the javelin throw. He won with such ease and such obvious superiority that the crowd, which had been cheering for the Trojan princes, fell gradually silent, and the silence had the quality of awe, which is the silence that falls when people are watching something they do not understand but suspect is important. Deiphobus, who had expected to win the wrestling and did not enjoy losing at the best of times and particularly did not enjoy losing to an unknown herdsman in front of the entire city, grew first red, then white, then drew his sword, which was the sort of escalation that Deiphobus was known for and that Hecuba had spent years trying to correct.

The young herdsman, seeing the sword, ran.

He ran through the streets of Troy with Deiphobus behind him and a growing crowd of onlookers following both, and he ran, with the unerring instinct of someone being guided by a force he did not recognise, to the altar of Zeus Herkeios, the Zeus of the Courtyard, which stood at the heart of the palace complex and which was, by ancient and inviolable custom, a place of sanctuary where no blood could be shed. He threw himself against the altar and clung to it, panting, and Deiphobus stood over him with his sword raised and his face twisted with the particular kind of

fury that is actually humiliation wearing a mask, and the crowd held its breath, and Cassandra screamed.

She had been watching from the upper windows of the palace, and she screamed the way she always screamed, with her whole body, with her hands clawing at the air and her hair wild and her eyes so wide that the whites showed all around the dark irises, and what she screamed was this:

“Kill him! Kill him now! He is the torch! He is the fire! He will burn us all!”

No one listened. No one ever listened to Cassandra, which was the specific and deliberate cruelty of her curse: not that she could see the future, but that seeing it was useless, that knowledge without the power to act on it is not wisdom but torment, and that she would live her entire life trapped in the gap between what she knew and what she could make anyone else believe, which is a kind of hell that does not require flames.

What happened next was recognition, and it changed everything.

Agelaus, the herdsman, had come to the games with the young man he had raised, and when he saw the boy at the altar, saw the sword, saw the chaos, he pushed through the crowd and fell to his knees before Priam and told him everything. He told him about the five days on the mountain. He told him about the bear. He told him about raising the boy as his own, about the extraordinary beauty and the unsettling charm and the way the cattle seemed to

follow the boy of their own accord, which should perhaps have been a warning sign but which Agelaus had interpreted as a useful agricultural skill. He told him that the young herdsman clinging to the altar of Zeus was Paris, son of Priam, son of Hecuba, prince of Troy, the child who was supposed to be dead.

Priam wept.

This was, it must be said, exactly the wrong response. The correct response, the response that would have saved Troy and everyone in it, was to order Deiphobus to complete the stroke he had been about to deliver before Cassandra's scream interrupted him, to let the sword fall, to let the blood flow, to let the prophecy be fulfilled in its negation. But Priam was old, and he was sentimental, and his son was alive, his beautiful, lost son was alive and kneeling at the altar of Zeus with honey-coloured eyes and a smile that promised wonderful things, and the father in him was stronger than the king in him, which is understandable and forgivable and fatal.

He embraced Paris. He brought him into the palace. He dressed him in silk and gold and gave him apartments near the royal quarters and introduced him to his brothers and sisters as the lost prince, restored by the grace of the gods, a miracle, a gift, a sign of divine favour.

Hecuba watched all of this from the doorway of the great hall, and her face showed nothing. Not joy. Not fear. Not recognition of the child she had held for one hour twenty

years ago. Nothing at all, except a stillness so complete that it seemed almost inhuman, the stillness of a woman who is looking at the instrument of her own destruction and has not yet decided what to feel about it.

She looked at Paris. She looked for the baby in the man, for some trace of the infant she had memorised, the curl of the ear, the shade of the lower lip, and she found it, or imagined she found it, which amounts to the same thing. And she felt the grief she had folded and stored in the dark place inside herself stir, and shift, and begin, very slowly, to unfold.

She said nothing.

She accepted Paris back. She welcomed him. She had rooms prepared for him and clothes made for him and she sat across from him at dinner and watched him charm his brothers and enchant the court and she thought about the torch and the fire and the screaming, and she said nothing, because what was there to say? Priam had decided. The seer's prophecy was twenty years old and the child was alive and the gods had clearly willed his survival, and who was Hecuba to argue with the gods?

(She would have argued with the gods if she thought it would do any good. She would have argued with Zeus himself, and she would have made a better case than most. But arguing with a husband who has already made up his mind is, in practical terms, even less productive than

arguing with a god, because gods at least have the excuse of being divine, while husbands are merely stubborn.)

Paris settled into the palace like water settling into a crack in stone, naturally and inevitably and with consequences that would not become apparent until it was far too late. He was charming. He was beautiful. He was entirely, breathtakingly useless in all the ways that mattered and spectacularly gifted in all the ways that did not. He could not lead men or manage accounts or negotiate treaties or do any of the hundred practical things that princes of Troy were expected to do, but he could play the lyre like Apollo himself (a comparison that should have alarmed everyone, given Apollo's complicated history with the house of Troy, but that was instead offered as a compliment, which tells you something about the dangers of flattery), and he could charm the sandals off a Spartan emissary, and he could look at you with those honey-coloured eyes and make you feel, for just a moment, that you were the only person in the world, which is a gift that is indistinguishable from a weapon when wielded by someone who does not understand the damage it can do.

Hector liked him, which surprised Hecuba and worried her in equal measure. Hector, who was usually an excellent judge of character (perhaps because his own character was so uncomplicated and so solid that it served as a reliable standard of measurement), seemed to see something in Paris that no one else could see, some core of goodness or

potential beneath the charm and the beauty and the slightly maddening insouciance. He took Paris hunting and taught him to throw a javelin properly and introduced him to the officers of the army and the elders of the council, and he did all of this with the patient, slightly exasperated affection of an older brother who has decided to take a project on and is determined to see it through, regardless of how many times the project catches its own hair on fire.

Hecuba watched. She was very good at watching. She had been watching for fifty-two years, watching her husband and her children and her city and her enemies, and she had developed the ability to see things that other people missed, not because her eyes were sharper but because she was willing to look at things that other people preferred to look away from. She watched Paris, and she saw the torch, and she said nothing, and she waited.

What she was waiting for, she could not have said. Perhaps for the prophecy to prove itself wrong, for Paris to grow into a man who could be trusted, who could be contained, who could burn without setting everything around him alight. Perhaps for a sign from the gods, though she put little faith in signs, having seen too many of them interpreted too freely by too many people with too many agendas. Perhaps she was simply waiting for the inevitable, which is what people do when they can see a disaster approaching and cannot stop it and have too much dignity to scream.

The inevitable, when it came, came from the sea.

Priam decided to send Paris on a diplomatic mission to Sparta. This was one of those decisions that seemed reasonable at the time and insane in retrospect, like building a house at the base of a volcano or keeping a pet lion, decisions that can only be made by people who have successfully convinced themselves that the obvious risk is somehow not applicable in their particular case. Sparta was across the sea, in the Peloponnese, and its king was Menelaus, a thickset, red-haired man of no particular brilliance but considerable determination, and his wife was Helen.

Helen.

There is no point in describing Helen, because she has been described too many times by too many poets, and every description is simultaneously too much and not enough, because beauty of the kind that Helen possessed cannot be captured in words any more than the sea can be captured in a jar. It was said that she was the most beautiful woman in the world, and it was said that her face could launch a thousand ships, and both of these things turned out to be literally true, which is the only time in recorded history that poetic hyperbole was later confirmed by actual events. She was the daughter of Zeus himself (by Leda, a queen of Sparta who had the misfortune of attracting the attention of the king of the gods, which never ended well for anyone except Zeus), and she had been married to

Menelaus not because she loved him but because he had won her in a competition among suitors that was complicated and political and ultimately irrelevant, since the marriage was always going to end the same way, with fire and blood and the sound of ships.

Paris went to Sparta. Paris met Helen. Paris took Helen.

Whether Helen went willingly is a question that has been debated for three thousand years and will be debated for three thousand more, because it is one of those questions that reveals more about the person asking it than about the answer, and the answer, in any case, does not matter, because the result was the same regardless. Paris came back to Troy with Helen, and the world came after her, and Hecuba, standing on the western terrace of the palace and watching the ship with the Spartan queen aboard glide into the harbour like a beautiful, poisoned gift, felt the dream of the torch flare behind her eyes with a brightness that she had spent twenty years trying to forget, and she knew, with the absolute, iron certainty of a woman who has always been right about everything and who would have given anything, anything at all, to be wrong just this once, that it had begun.

She went to Priam. She argued. She used every tool in her considerable arsenal: reason, precedent, economic analysis, strategic calculation, an appeal to his legacy and his name and the names of all his sons. She told him that keeping Helen would bring war, that the Greeks would

come, that Menelaus would rally every king and every warrior in the Greek world to his cause, because this was not merely a matter of a stolen wife but of honour, which was the currency that Greek kings dealt in and the only one they valued more than gold. She was logical. She was passionate. She was right.

Priam listened, and hesitated, and looked at Paris, who stood beside Helen with his hand in hers and his beautiful face alight with the particular glow of a man who believes he has done something wonderful and cannot understand why everyone is not celebrating, and Priam's resolve, which had never been as firm as Hecuba would have liked (this was the softness she had always seen in him, the yielding quality that she had spent their entire marriage trying to shore up with her own rigidity, the way a beam of iron supports a wall of clay), crumbled.

"The gods brought her here," Paris said, and the worst part was that he believed it, and the second worst part was that he was probably right, though not in the way he meant. Aphrodite had promised him the most beautiful woman in the world in exchange for a golden apple and a judgment that was none of his business (a story that belongs elsewhere and that Hecuba, who had heard it from Paris himself and found it grotesquely self-serving, refused to think about), and Paris, with the serene confidence of a man who has never been denied anything, believed that divine sanction made everything acceptable, which is the

most dangerous belief a human being can hold and the one most commonly held by people who are about to destroy everything around them.

Helen stayed. The embassy from Menelaus was refused. The ships began to gather on the far shore of the Aegean, a thousand ships, just as Cassandra had screamed, just as the dream had warned, and Hecuba stood on the western terrace and watched the horizon and felt the future pressing in on her like the walls of a room that was slowly, inexorably contracting, and she did the only thing she had ever known how to do in the face of the impossible.

She prepared.

She ordered the grain stores expanded. She had the wells deepened and new cisterns dug inside the citadel. She inspected the walls (which were god-built and therefore theoretically impervious, but Hecuba had never been the sort of woman who trusted theory over observation, and what she observed was that even god-built walls develop cracks if no one maintains them). She reviewed the armoury, the hospital supplies, the stockpile of arrows and javelins and spare chariot wheels. She organised the women of the palace into a support force that could cook, tend wounds, carry supplies, and, if necessary, fight, because Hecuba understood, in a way that Priam and his council of elderly men did not, that a siege is won or lost not on the battlefield but in the kitchens and the storerooms and the hospitals, in the unglamorous, unsung, indispensable work

that keeps an army alive while it waits for the enemy to make a mistake.

And she looked at Paris, who was strolling through the gardens with Helen on his arm and a smile on his face and not a care in the world, and she thought about the torch, and the fire, and the screaming, and she thought: I should have done it myself. I should have taken the child to the mountain myself, with my own hands, and I should have stayed until it was done, because the thing you trust to others is the thing that comes back to destroy you.

But she had not. And it was too late. And the ships were coming.

Across the Aegean, a thousand kings were sharpening their swords, and in the palace of Troy, Cassandra screamed and screamed and screamed, and no one listened, and the dream of the torch burned on behind Hecuba's eyes like a coal that would never go cold, and the war, the war that would end everything, the war that would take her sons and her husband and her grandchildren and her city and her crown and her name and her very humanity, drew closer with every tide.

And Hecuba prepared, because preparation was the only prayer she knew, and because doing something, even something insufficient, is better than doing nothing, which is what despair looks like when it forgets to get dressed in the morning.

The ships came.

The rest of the book

That is where the sample stops. What follows is ten years of siege, and then the part the poets tended to hurry past: what happened to the woman who was still standing when the city was not.

Hecuba was fifty-two years old, Queen of Troy, mother of nineteen children, and the most competent person in any room she entered. The myths remember what she became. They are less forthcoming about what it cost.

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